



The UK's AI Skills Ambition

A target, a measurement, and a number nobody can check

Independent research report. Preliminary findings from a project at its research and pilot-design stage. Evidence, inference and opinion are distinguished throughout, and every source is tagged by its likely interest. Interests are declared in §8.

Overview

The UK Government intends to upskill 10 million workers in AI by 2030. In January 2026 it reported that 1,001,147 courses had been completed toward that target.

Those courses were delivered by eleven companies: Accenture, Amazon, BT, Barclays, IBM, Google, Intuit, Microsoft, SAS, Sage and Salesforce. The figure counts their customers and their own employees alike, and includes the civil service's internal learning day. No partner-level or course-level breakdown is published. The Department for Science, Innovation and Technology states that these are not shareable due to commercial sensitivity.

Over the same period the government's own AI skills programme, BridgeAI, recorded 1,700 course completions and 126 accreditations, against £74.6 million allocated from a £100 million budget.

Both sets of numbers are published by the government. Neither appears next to the other.

Several things should be conceded at the outset. A million completions is not nothing. Using training the technology industry already provides free is a legitimate policy choice, not self-evidently a failure. Skills England produced a benchmark and checked courses against it. And the department's own economic modelling publishes its equations and describes itself as highly uncertain, which is better practice than most of the figures quoted in this area.

What follows is narrower than a verdict on the programme. It asks whether the figures government reports progress against can be checked by anyone outside it, and what happened the last time it published figures of this kind. The argument is built from government's own published material throughout.

1. The ambition, and the gap nobody had measured

The AI Opportunities Action Plan was published in January 2025. It was written by Matt Clifford, an adviser commissioned by the Secretary of State, and presented to Parliament as Command Paper CP 1241. It makes fifty recommendations. It is not itself a statement of policy; the government's response, CP 1242, is.

Its fourteenth recommendation concerns the evidence base underneath everything else in its skills section.

Current estimates are imprecise and outdated... The success of the following recommendations depends on accurately understanding the skills gap.

— AI Opportunities Action Plan, Recommendation 14, January 2025

The last government-funded AI labour market survey had been carried out in 2020. The jobs and skills dashboard it also cites was using supply data from 2019.

The government agreed. Its response committed Skills England to develop “a clear assessment of the country’s skills need – including AI and digital skills – and map pathways by which they can be filled”, working with businesses, training partners, unions and both national and local government.

The problem, stated	Estimates “imprecise and outdated”. Last survey 2020; dashboard data from 2019.
The commitment	A clear assessment of the country’s skills need, led by Skills England.
Who was to be involved	Businesses, training partners, unions, and national and local government.
Cadence promised	“Updated assessments will be published regularly.”
Target date given	Spring 2025.

Source: HM Government, *AI Opportunities Action Plan (CP 1241)* and *AI Opportunities Action Plan: government response (CP 1242)*, both 13 January 2025.



NOTE

On the status of these two documents

The Action Plan is an independent adviser's report and does not commit government to anything. The response is where commitments are made, and it answers each recommendation individually with a target date. Forty-eight were agreed and two partially agreed, so the widely repeated claim that all fifty were accepted is very nearly, but not exactly, right.



2. What arrived instead

A survey was commissioned. The AI Labour Market Survey 2025, carried out for the department by the consultancy Gardiner & Theobald, states that its findings “contribute to meeting that recommendation”.

119	Organisations responding.
3,940	Organisations contacted.
3%	Response rate, as stated in the report.
50%	Share of respondents based in Greater London.
9	Respondents from Scotland, Wales and Northern Ireland combined.

Source: DSIT and Gardiner & Theobald, *AI Labour Market Survey 2025*, sections 2 and 3. Twenty interviews were conducted, against fifty in the 2020 study.



The survey defines its market as UK organisations “who are commercially developing AI, those who are internally developing AI and those who are procuring AI”. Two thirds of respondents are building AI commercially. It measures the AI industry's demand for AI professionals.

Its authors state, before any findings are presented, that “self-selection participation to the survey may create a biased sample”. The report also records that its findings “do not represent Government views or policy”.



WHAT THIS DOES NOT CLAIM

This survey is one input, not the whole of the government's response to Recommendation 14. Skills England's own assessment work exists and is not examined here, and nothing above shows the commitment was abandoned. The narrower observation is this: the artefact most visibly produced under that heading measures a different and much smaller population than the ten-million-worker target names.

 3. A target counted in workers, a figure counted in courses

AI Skills Boost was announced by the Prime Minister at London Tech Week in June 2025 and carries the ten-million-worker target. The AI Skills Hub is its platform. In January 2026 the department published its progress: 1,001,147 courses completed.

The figure covers, in the department's own words, “all AI skills courses delivered by partners since June 2025, from introductory AI literacy to advanced training in areas like data science and machine learning engineering, for both external learners (customers, clients, platform users) and internal learners (partner employees)”.

Unit counted	Courses completed. The target it reports against is expressed in workers.
Supplied by	Eleven commercial partners, self-reported to the department in January 2026.
Who is counted	Customers, clients and platform users, alongside the partners' own employees.
Also included	Courses delivered through One Big Thing, the civil service's internal learning day.
Breakdown published	None. Withheld as commercially sensitive.
Restricted to UK learners	Not stated.

Source: DSIT, AI Skills Boost: explainer, 28 January 2026. The same figure appears in both ministerial forewords to AI Opportunities Action Plan: One Year On, published the following day.

Specific partner or course-level breakdowns of course completion are not shareable due to commercial sensitivity.

— DSIT, AI Skills Boost: explainer, January 2026

Skills England published an AI foundation skills for work benchmark alongside the programme, and a selection of industry-developed courses on the Hub were checked against it. The million-course figure is not drawn from that selection. It spans everything the partners delivered, including advanced machine-learning training well outside a foundation-skills standard. How much of it meets the benchmark is not published.



4. This has happened before

In April 2020 the Department for Education launched The Skills Toolkit: over £1 million of public money on a page signposting to free online courses from Amazon, Microsoft, LinkedIn, the Open University and Google.

In March 2021 the Office for Statistics Regulation wrote to the department's chief statistician about the figures it had been publishing.

Delivery model	Government-branded signposting to free vendor courses. The same in both programmes.
Figures supplied by	The course providers themselves. The same in both programmes.
What “completion” meant	2021: the regulator found it could mean a user had accessed material, not finished a course. 2026: not defined publicly.
Geographic filter	2021: none; registrations were unfiltered and could come from anywhere in the world. 2026: not stated.
Use in Parliament	2021: inaccurate figures given, and unpublished data used in answers. 2026: cited in two ministerial forewords.
Regulator's finding	2021: figures moved to experimental statistics under the Code of Practice. 2026: —

Sources: Office for Statistics Regulation correspondence to DfE, March 2021, as reported by FE Week; DSIT, AI Skills Boost: explainer, January 2026. The OSR letter itself has not been read directly — see §8.



THE EMPTY CELL

One row has no entry for 2026

Every row above has a 2021 entry because a regulator examined the programme and published what it found. The last row is blank for 2026 because no equivalent examination has been made. That is the difference between the two programmes on the evidence available — not that one is known to be unsound and the other sound.

Sue Pember, policy lead at HOLEX, the adult and community education body, drew the comparison when the new programme launched.

While the ambition is positive, the lesson from the skills toolkit should be that take-up and outcomes matter more than headline registration numbers.

— Sue Pember, HOLEX, quoted in FE Week

The programme also introduced digital badges for course completion. The chair of Skills England described them as “a huge step forward” and “a simple idea that will make a huge difference”. The Open Badges standard was published in 2011.

5. Who supplies the evidence

PwC was commissioned, following what Innovate UK describes as a robust competitive tender, to design, build and run the AI Skills Hub. PwC is also named as a delivery partner of the programme.

Separately, Innovate UK's February 2026 white paper states that its quantitative benchmarking was mainly drawn from large-scale datasets including the PwC Global CEO Survey, the AI Jobs



Barometer and the Global Hopes and Fears Survey. PwC surveys are cited three times in that paper's own argument for the scale of the skills gap.

So one commercial firm built the platform, helps deliver the programme, and is a principal supplier of the evidence used to argue that the platform is needed. Competitive tendering is the normal route for public procurement, and nothing here suggests the process was improper. The issue is evidential independence, not procurement propriety.

The same pattern appears at the top of the funnel. The £400 billion economic figure cited across government communications, including in the Action Plan itself, is footnoted there to Public First's Google's Impact in the UK 2023. The same consultancy separately produced a UK AI economic report commissioned by Microsoft. Neither observation requires assuming anyone acted in bad faith. Both mean the evidence base is more concentrated in interested parties than its presentation suggests.

No response from Innovate UK, PwC, Digital Catapult or DSIT to these observations has been sought at the time of writing. That is a gap in this report and should be closed before these findings are treated as settled — see §8.

6. What the evidence says would work

The government's own PRIMES framework, published in June 2026 under the same research programme that produced the AI skills tooling, sets out six principles for effective AI training. Each row below adds one concrete requirement from its criteria document.

Practical	Links to real tasks; recognises existing informal AI use rather than assuming a zero starting point; states when AI should and should not be used.
Reachable	Accessible in time, format and language; designed around intersecting barriers of income, age, disability and gender, not a single average learner.
Integrated	Fits existing systems and standards; mandatory before staff use AI on regulated, confidential or safety-critical work.
Modular	Short, stackable units of 30–90 minutes, with entry at different levels and clear return points.
Expandable	Builds transferable skills across tools and roles rather than single-vendor competence.
Sustainable	Reviewed on a set cadence, with 3- and 6-month revisits; tracks confidence and quality of judgement, not just enrolment.

Two further points come from outside that programme. Sequencing research describes shifting responsibility progressively from instructor to learner, through modelling, then guided practice, then independent practice. And evidence on AI literacy training suggests it can improve how well people calibrate their own confidence, which matters because surface familiarity with AI can increase misplaced trust rather than reduce it.

There is also a working counter-example. Elements of AI, from MinnaLearn and the University of Helsinki, is vendor-neutral, requires no technical prerequisite, and is structured as short chapters combining theory, exercises and self-reflection. It has reportedly reached around one million learners. That demonstrates reach at scale; it is not, on its own, evidence of measured learning outcomes.

7. Where this project fits

Grounded AI Practice is an independent research project, not a competitor to a national platform, and it is careful about the difference. Its working decisions to date:

Initial audience	Individuals seeking practical everyday AI literacy, with particular attention to employees at small organisations who lack the employer-provided L&D infrastructure that both PRIMES and the AI Skills Hub assume.
First output	A single pilot learning unit — not a roadmap, course library or platform — sized to PRIMES' modular criterion and sequenced accordingly, tested with real learners before anything wider is built.
Pilot capability	Effective prompting, chosen to show a learner the gap between what they type and what the model actually does with it, while teaching an immediately usable skill.

The scale difference is the point, not an apology for it. A national platform with a ten-million-worker target cannot easily run a small, well-sequenced pilot and learn from it. An independent project can, and the evidence above suggests that is exactly the step that was skipped.

8. Method, limitations and declared interests

Findings here draw on primary sources read directly wherever possible. The AI Opportunities Action Plan and its government response, the AI Skills Boost explainer, One Year On, the AI Labour Market Survey 2025 and both Innovate UK documents were obtained and read. Every source is tagged by its likely interest so that concentration in the evidence base is visible rather than hidden. Where a finding would materially affect this project's direction, confirming and disconfirming evidence was sought together.

Specific limitations, stated directly:

- No response has been sought from Innovate UK, PwC, Digital Catapult or DSIT. The observations in §5 are one-sided until that is done, and it should be done before publication rather than after.
- The Office for Statistics Regulation's 2021 correspondence has not been read directly. The account in §4 rests on FE Week's reporting of it across two articles, and the £1 million figure is likewise second-hand.
- The AI Labour Market Survey is one input to Recommendation 14, not the whole of the government's response to it. Skills England's own assessment work has not been tested against the commitment's wording.
- All BridgeAI delivery figures are self-reported by a consortium delivery partner writing for its funder. No independent audit or evaluation of BridgeAI or the AI Skills Hub has been located.
- The £400 billion figure's underlying model has not been independently reviewed. Its provenance has been traced through the Action Plan's own footnote; the Google-commissioned report itself has not been read.
- Whether the 1,001,147 figure is restricted to UK learners is unknown. A Freedom of Information request on that, on the internal and external learner split, and on the operational definition of “completed”, is the obvious next step and this project intends to make one.

Declared interests

This report is published by a project that proposes an alternative approach to the one it examines. That is a real interest and is declared plainly: the author benefits if this analysis is found persuasive. Readers should weigh the evidence accordingly, which is why the argument is built as far as possible from government-published material that can be checked independently.

The project has received no funding, sponsorship or support from any organisation named in this report, and holds no commercial relationship with any of them.

Sources

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Full source list, interest tagging and entry-by-entry findings are maintained in the Grounded AI Practice project repository.

